

The “Don’t allow exceptions” option allows no internal software to accept outside connections.

The next tab is “Exceptions”. It allows certain programs to accept connections from the Internet which would otherwise be blocked. You can choose ‘Add Program’ to add any application from a list of all that are installed on your PC to accept connections. For example, if you want to accept connections for Remote Assistance or Remote Desktop which is disabled by default, you can do so by clicking the ‘Exceptions’ tab and checking the box. You can follow the same procedure and have a greater control over programs such as P2P clients and IM software.

The ‘Advanced’ tab contains several options. The most important is the Services settings. You can access these by highlighting your Internet connection in the ‘Network Connection Settings’ window and clicking ‘Settings’.

The Services allow information to pass through certain ports, similar to the Exceptions. Ports are communication channels for software and are represented numerically. Different network communication protocols work on different ports. So if two computers, one the client and another the server, are connected, and the client wants to access a service on the server, the client connects to a standard port for that particular service on the server. For example, MSN messenger connects to Internet using port 1863, and Yahoo! Messenger uses port 5050. If you want other programs to accept connections from the Internet and the program is not in the list, but you know the port number, then you can type in the port number and “open” it. An example would be that of a P2P client; visiting the product’s forum page would inform you that a certain port needs to be unblocked for the software to function.

Other than protecting your system, Firewalls also help conserve bandwidth by preventing unwanted Internet access by certain programs.